

# The \$0 Cold Email System: Land Clients Without Paying for Tools

## Product Overview

A complete cold email system using only free tools. No \$200/month Instantly subscription. No \$150/month Apollo. No \$99/month Lemlist. You'll set up infrastructure, find prospects, personalize outreach at scale, send sequences, and close deals — spending \$0 on software.

This isn't theory. These are the exact systems freelancers and agency owners use to land \$2K-\$10K/month clients through cold outreach.

## Pricing

**\$37** (one-time)

## Target Audience

- Freelancers who need clients but can't afford \$400+/month in outreach tools
- Agency owners starting from zero who need a pipeline before they can invest in paid tools
- Consultants who know their service is valuable but don't know how to reach buyers
- Anyone who's tried cold email before and got zero responses

## What's Inside

| Chapter | Title           | Outcome                                                      |
|---------|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1       | Infrastructure  | 3 email accounts on custom domains, warmed and ready to send |
| 2       | Prospecting     | A list of 500+ qualified prospects built with free tools     |
| 3       | Personalization | AI-personalized emails that don't sound AI-generated         |
| 4       | Sequences       | 7 proven email sequences you can deploy today                |

| Chapter | Title   | Outcome                                                         |
|---------|---------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5       | Closing | Reply handling, call booking, and proposal templates that close |

## Guarantee

Follow Chapters 1-4. If you send 200 emails using the system and don't get at least 10 positive responses, email for a full refund with proof of send.

## Format

- 5 chapters, each 800-1500 words
- Real tool names with setup instructions
- Real email templates (not AI-generated slop)
- DNS configuration walkthroughs with screenshots description
- Proposal templates and call scripts included

# Chapter 1: Free Email Infrastructure That Doesn't Land in Spam

## What You'll Have After This Chapter

Three email accounts on custom domains with proper DNS authentication, warmed up and ready to send cold emails without landing in spam. Total cost: \$10/year per domain. Total tool cost: \$0.

## Why Infrastructure Matters More Than Copy

You could write the best cold email in history. If your domain has no reputation and your DNS records are wrong, it's going to spam. 76% of cold emails never reach the inbox. Not because the content is bad — because the sender's infrastructure is broken.

Fix the infrastructure first. Then worry about what you're writing.

## Step 1: Buy 3 Domains (15 minutes)

Don't send cold emails from your primary domain. If your main domain gets flagged, your entire business email goes to spam. That's a recovery process that takes 4-6 weeks and sometimes never fully recovers.

Buy 3 secondary domains. They should look related to your main brand but different enough that if one gets burned, the others survive.

Example: If your business is `acmedesign.com`: - `acmedesign.co` - `acmedigital.com` - `getacme.com`

Where to buy: - **Porkbun**: \$9-11/year for a .com, free WHOIS privacy - **Namecheap**: \$8-12/year, \$2.88 first year promotions regularly - **Cloudflare Registrar**: At-cost pricing, usually \$9-10/year

Don't use GoDaddy. Their markup is 30-50% higher and their upselling is relentless.

You're spending \$27-33/year on 3 domains. This is your only cost.

## Step 2: Set Up Free Email Accounts (20 minutes per domain)

You need actual email accounts on each domain. Three free options:

### Option A: Zoho Mail (Free Plan)

Zoho's free plan gives you 5 email accounts per domain with 5GB storage each. This is the best free option.

1. Go to `mail.zoho.com` and sign up
2. Click "Add Domain" and enter your domain
3. Zoho gives you DNS records to add. Go to your domain registrar and add:
  - MX records (these tell the internet where your email lives)
  - TXT record for domain verification
4. Create your email: `yourname@yourdomain.com`
5. Repeat for all 3 domains

### Option B: ImprovMX + Gmail (Free)

ImprovMX forwards emails from your custom domain to your Gmail. Free plan allows 25 forwarding addresses.

1. Go to `improvmx.com` and add your domain
2. Add the MX records they provide to your DNS
3. In Gmail, go to Settings > Accounts > "Send mail as" and add your custom domain email
4. Gmail will send a verification email — confirm it
5. Now you can send AND receive from your custom domain using Gmail's interface

### Option C: Cloudflare Email Routing + Gmail (Free)

If your domain is on Cloudflare:

1. Dashboard > Email > Email Routing

2. Add a forwarding rule: yourname@yourdomain.com forwards to your Gmail
3. In Gmail, add it as a “Send mail as” address (same process as Option B)

Whichever option you choose, create one email account per domain. Use professional names: - alex@acmedesign.co (good) - contact@acmedesign.co (too generic for cold email) - alex.smith@acmedesign.co (good if your name is common)

## Step 3: DNS Configuration (30 minutes total)

This is the part most people skip, and it’s why their emails go to spam. You need three DNS records per domain: SPF, DKIM, and DMARC.

### SPF (Sender Policy Framework)

SPF tells receiving servers which mail servers are authorized to send email from your domain.

Add a TXT record to your DNS:

Type: TXT  
Host: @  
Value: v=spf1 include:zoho.com ~all

If using Gmail/ImprovMX:

Value: v=spf1 include:\_spf.google.com include:improvmx.com ~all

**Important:** You can only have ONE SPF record per domain. If you need multiple services, combine them into one record with multiple include: statements.

### DKIM (DomainKeys Identified Mail)

DKIM adds a cryptographic signature to your emails, proving they came from you and weren’t tampered with.

- **Zoho:** Go to Mail Admin Console > Email Authentication > DKIM. Zoho generates the record. Add it to your DNS as a TXT record.
- **Gmail:** Google Workspace has DKIM built in. For free Gmail with ImprovMX, DKIM is handled by Google’s servers.

The record looks something like:

Type: TXT  
Host: zoho.\_domainkey  
Value: v=DKIM1; k=rsa; p=MIGfMA0GCSqGSIb3DQEBAQUAA4...(long key)

### DMARC (Domain-based Message Authentication)

DMARC tells receiving servers what to do if SPF or DKIM fails.

Add a TXT record:

Type: TXT

Host: \_dmarc

Value: v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc@yourdomain.com

Start with p=none (monitor mode). This tells receivers to deliver emails even if checks fail, but send you reports. After 2 weeks of successful sending, change to p=quarantine.

## Verify Your Setup

Go to [mxtoolbox.com/SuperTool.aspx](https://mxtoolbox.com/SuperTool.aspx) and run these checks: - MX Lookup: Confirms your mail server is configured - SPF Record Lookup: Confirms SPF is valid - DKIM Test: Send an email to [check-auth@verifier.port25.com](mailto:check-auth@verifier.port25.com) — you'll get a report back - DMARC Lookup: Confirms your DMARC policy

All three should show green checks. If any fail, fix them before sending a single cold email.

## Step 4: Domain Warming (14 days)

A brand-new domain sending 50 emails on day one gets flagged instantly. You need to warm it up — establish sending reputation gradually.

### Free Warming Method (Manual)

Days 1-3: Send 3-5 personal emails per day to friends, colleagues, and yourself. Have them reply to every email. Open, read, and reply to all responses.

Days 4-7: Send 10-15 emails per day. Mix personal emails with emails to yourself at different providers (Gmail, Outlook, Yahoo). Have conversations — reply threads build reputation faster than one-off sends.

Days 8-14: Send 15-25 emails per day. Start subscribing to newsletters and replying to mailing list emails from this address. The goal is diverse, two-way email activity.

### Semi-Automated Warming

**InboxAlly** has a free tier (limited). Sign up at [inboxally.com](https://inboxally.com). It sends seed emails to your address and engages with them (opens, clicks, replies, moves from spam to inbox). This trains Gmail and Outlook to trust your domain.

**Warmup Inbox** ([warmupinbox.com](https://warmupinbox.com)) — free tier available. Similar concept.

### What “Warmed” Looks Like

After 14 days: - You can send 50-75 emails/day per domain without spam issues - Your emails land in Primary (Gmail) or Inbox (Outlook), not Promotions or Spam - Your domain has a neutral-to-positive reputation

Test by sending an email to `mail-tester.com`. They score you 1-10. You want 7+ before starting outreach.

## Step 5: Sending Infrastructure

Don't send cold emails from your email client (Gmail, Zoho webmail). You need a sending tool that handles scheduling, follow-ups, and tracking.

### Free Sending Tools

**GMass** (free tier): 50 emails/day for free. Works inside Gmail. Handles sequences, follow-ups, and basic tracking. This is the best free option if you're using Gmail.

To set up: 1. Install the GMass Chrome extension 2. Connect your Gmail account 3. Create a Google Sheet with your prospect list (Name, Email, Company columns) 4. Compose your email in Gmail 5. GMass personalizes and schedules sends from the Sheet

**Mailmeteor** (free tier): 50 emails/day. Also works inside Gmail/Google Sheets. Simpler than GMass but limited to single sends (no sequences on free plan).

**Yet Another Mail Merge (YAMM)**: 50 emails/day free tier. Google Sheets integration.

### Sending Rules

- **Never send more than 50 emails per domain per day.** Across 3 domains, that's 150 emails/day — more than enough.
- **Space sends 60-120 seconds apart.** Bulk blasts at the same timestamp scream spam.
- **Send between 8 AM - 11 AM in your prospect's timezone.** Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday are highest open rate days.
- **Don't use tracking pixels** on cold emails. Google's AI detects tracking pixels and deprioritizes those emails. Use reply rate as your metric instead of open rate.
- **Plain text only.** No HTML templates, no images, no logos. Plain text emails get 2-3x higher deliverability in cold outreach.

## Infrastructure Checklist

Before moving to Chapter 2, confirm:

- ☐ 3 domains purchased and DNS pointed correctly
- ☐ Email accounts created on each domain
- ☐ SPF record added and verified on all 3 domains
- ☐ DKIM record added and verified on all 3 domains
- ☐ DMARC record added on all 3 domains
- ☐ mail-tester.com score of 7+ on all 3 accounts
- ☐ 14 days of warming completed (or warming tool running)
- ☐ GMass or alternative sending tool installed and configured
- ☐ Test email sent to yourself and landing in Primary inbox

If any of these are incomplete, stop here and fix them. Sending cold emails on broken infrastructure is worse than not sending at all — you'll burn domains that take 2 weeks to set up.

Next chapter: Finding 500+ qualified prospects using only free tools.

## Chapter 2: Finding Leads With Free Tools

### What You'll Have After This Chapter

A spreadsheet of 500+ qualified prospects with their name, email, company, and a personalization data point — built entirely with free tools. No Apollo subscription. No ZoomInfo contract. No \$150/month lead database.

### The Lead Qualification Framework

Before you find a single lead, define who you're looking for. A bad list with perfect emails produces nothing. A great list with mediocre emails produces clients.

Answer these five questions:

1. **What industry?** Pick one. Not “small businesses.” Pick “e-commerce stores doing \$500K-\$5M/year” or “B2B SaaS companies with 10-50 employees.” Specific.
2. **What role?** Who has the budget and authority to say yes? For most services: founder, CEO, or VP/Director of the relevant department. For design: marketing director. For development: CTO or VP Engineering. For SEO: CMO or founder.
3. **What signal means they need you?** Examples:
  - o “They’re hiring for the role I replace” (job posting on their careers page)
  - o “Their website has obvious issues” (slow, not mobile-friendly, broken checkout)
  - o “They just raised funding” (money to spend)
  - o “They’re running ads but their landing page is bad” (they’re spending on traffic but wasting it)
4. **What’s their budget?** If you charge \$3K/month, don’t target solo founders making \$50K/year. If you charge \$500/project, don’t target Fortune 500 (they’ll never respond to cold email).
5. **What’s your disqualifier?** Who do you explicitly NOT want? Too small? Wrong geography? Competitors? Define the “not this” list.

Write these down. You'll use them as filters for every prospecting method below.

## Method 1: Google Maps Scraping (Local Businesses)

If your target is local or regional businesses (restaurants, law firms, dentists, real estate agents, contractors), Google Maps is your database.

### The Process

1. Search Google Maps for [business type] in [city]
2. The results show business name, address, phone, website, and sometimes email
3. For each result that fits your ICP, collect: business name, owner name (check their website's About page), email, website URL

### Scaling It

Manually clicking through Google Maps results is slow. Use **Google Maps Scraper** by Outscraper (outscraper.com). The free tier gives you 500 records/month.

1. Enter your search query: “digital marketing agencies in Austin, TX”
2. Outscraper returns: business name, address, phone, website, Google rating, review count, category
3. Export to CSV
4. Visit each website to find the owner's name and email

This works for: restaurants, agencies, law firms, dentists, contractors, real estate, fitness studios, salons — any business with a physical location.

### Finding the Email

Most small business websites have the owner's email on the Contact or About page. If not:

**Hunter.io** (free tier): 25 searches/month. Enter the domain, get the email format and verified addresses. [hunter.io/search/domain.com](https://hunter.io/search/domain.com)

**RocketReach** (free tier): 5 lookups/month. Better for finding specific people's emails.

**The manual method:** Most business emails follow a pattern. If the owner is “John Smith” and the domain is “acmeagency.com,” try: - john@acmeagency.com - john.smith@acmeagency.com - jsmith@acmeagency.com

Verify which one works using **Email Hippo** (free) or **NeverBounce** (free verification for your first 1,000 emails).

## Method 2: LinkedIn Sales Navigator (Free Workaround)

LinkedIn Sales Navigator costs \$100/month. You don't need it. Here's the free alternative.



## Boolean Search on LinkedIn

LinkedIn's regular search supports Boolean operators. Use them:

"founder" AND "e-commerce" AND "Shopify" -recruiter -hiring

This finds founders of Shopify e-commerce stores who aren't recruiters or posting job ads.

More examples:

"CEO" AND "SaaS" AND ("series A" OR "seed funding")

"marketing director" AND "DTC" AND "brand"

"agency owner" AND ("web design" OR "development") AND "freelance"

## Extracting Contacts

LinkedIn doesn't show email addresses. But you can find them:

1. **Look at their LinkedIn profile** for an email in the "Contact Info" section (click the three dots, or check their About section)
2. **Check their personal website** (many list it on LinkedIn)
3. **Use their company domain + Hunter.io** to find their email pattern
4. **Use Snov.io free tier** (50 credits/month): Enter a LinkedIn URL, get their email

## Scaling LinkedIn Prospecting

**PhantomBuster free tier:** Automate LinkedIn profile scraping. 14-day trial, then limited free actions. Extract names, titles, and company info from search results.

**Export LinkedIn connections:** If you're already connected with prospects, go to Settings > Data Privacy > Get a copy of your data. LinkedIn emails you a CSV of all your connections with their emails.

## Building the List

Create a Google Sheet with these columns: - First Name - Last Name - Email - Company - Title - LinkedIn URL - Personalization Note (we'll use this in Chapter 3)

Target: 100+ qualified prospects from LinkedIn.

## Method 3: Competitor Customer Poaching

Find companies already using your competitor's product. They've validated the need — they just haven't found you yet.

## How to Find Competitor Customers

**Wappalyzer** (free browser extension): Detects the technology stack of any website. Visit a potential prospect's website, click Wappalyzer, and see what tools they use.

If you sell Webflow development, find companies using Squarespace or Wix (they're on inferior platforms and might want to upgrade). Wappalyzer tells you exactly what they're running.

**BuiltWith** (free tier): Enter a technology (e.g., "Klaviyo," "Shopify," "WordPress") and see a list of websites using it. The free tier gives limited results; the paid tier is expensive. Use the free tier to build a starter list.

**G2/Capterra reviews:** Go to your competitor's G2 or Capterra page. Read the reviews. The reviewer's name, title, and company are usually visible. These are people actively using (and sometimes unhappy with) a competing product.

**Twitter/X search:** Search for competitor mentions:

"[competitor name]" (frustrated OR broken OR switching OR alternative)

People complaining about your competitor are pre-qualified leads.

## The "Switching" Pitch

When you email someone who's using a competitor, your pitch is different from a standard cold email:

"I noticed you're using [Competitor]. How's that going? I ask because we work with a lot of [Competitor] customers who switched after hitting [SPECIFIC LIMITATION]. Happy to share what we did for [SIMILAR COMPANY] if useful."

This works because you're not selling against them — you're acknowledging their current choice and offering relevant experience.

## Method 4: Job Board Mining

Companies hiring for the role you fill are telling you they have budget and need. If they're hiring a full-time designer, they might also want a freelance designer while they search (or instead of hiring full-time).

### Where to Look

- **Indeed/LinkedIn Jobs:** Search for job titles related to your service. "Web Designer," "Content Writer," "SEO Specialist."
- **Wellfound (formerly AngelList):** Startups hiring. These companies are small enough that the founder reads their email.
- **Hacker News "Who is Hiring":** Monthly threads. Technical companies hiring. High-quality leads.
- **WeWorkRemotely:** Remote companies. Usually smaller, founder-led.

- **Craigslist:** Local businesses posting for help. They often have budget but don't know how to hire properly.

## The Extraction

For each job posting, collect: - Company name - Hiring manager (sometimes listed, sometimes you need to find them on LinkedIn) - Company website - What they're hiring for (this becomes your personalization)

## The Pitch

"I saw you're hiring a [ROLE]. While you're searching for the right full-time person, I can handle [SPECIFIC DELIVERABLE] on a project basis. I've done this for [SIMILAR COMPANY] — delivered [RESULT] in [TIMEFRAME]. Want me to send over a few examples?"

This isn't competing with their hire. It's filling the gap while they recruit. Many of these relationships turn into ongoing contracts when they realize a freelancer is more efficient than a full-time employee for their workload.

## Method 5: Community Mining

Your prospects are talking publicly in communities. They're asking questions, sharing challenges, and looking for help. Find them.

### Where to Mine

**Reddit:** Find subreddits where your prospects hang out. - For e-commerce clients: r/ecommerce, r/shopify, r/dropshipping - For SaaS clients: r/SaaS, r/startups, r/indiehackers - For agencies: r/agency, r/marketing, r/SEO

Search within subreddits for phrases like "looking for," "need help with," "can anyone recommend," "hire."

**Facebook Groups:** Join 5-10 groups where your prospects ask questions. Business owner groups, industry-specific groups, tool-specific groups (Shopify store owners, WordPress users, etc.).

**Slack/Discord communities:** Many industries have active Slack workspaces. Find them on [slofile.com](https://slofile.com) or [discord.com/servers](https://discord.com/servers). Join, lurk for a week, then start helping.

**Twitter/X:** Search for people asking for your service:

"looking for a designer" -job -hiring  
"need help with SEO" -course -free  
"can anyone recommend a developer"

## The Community Approach

Never cold pitch in communities. It gets you banned and destroys your reputation. Instead:

1. Find someone asking a question you can answer
2. Give a genuinely helpful answer in public
3. DM them with additional help (still not pitching)
4. If they ask about your services, THEN share what you do

The lead quality from communities is 10x higher than cold email. These people have already self-identified as having the problem you solve.

## Building Your Master List

By now you should have prospects from multiple sources. Consolidate everything into one Google Sheet:

| First Name | Last Name | Email          | Company | Title   | Source   | Personalization Note   |
|------------|-----------|----------------|---------|---------|----------|------------------------|
| Sarah      | Kim       | sarah@acme.com | Acme Co | Founder | LinkedIn | Just raised seed round |

### Email Verification (Critical)

Before you send a single email, verify every address. Sending to invalid emails raises your bounce rate, which tanks your sender reputation.

Free verification tools: - **NeverBounce**: 1,000 free verifications - **ZeroBounce**: 100 free verifications - **Email Hippo**: Single-email verification, unlimited free checks

Remove any email that comes back as “invalid” or “risky.” Your bounce rate should stay below 3%.

## The Numbers Game

Here’s what realistic cold email performance looks like:

- **500 prospects** on your list
- **15-25% open rate** (if your infrastructure is solid)
- **3-8% reply rate** (if your copy is good — Chapter 4)
- **15-40 replies** from 500 sends
- **5-15 positive replies** (interested in talking)
- **2-5 clients** (if your closing process works — Chapter 5)

If you charge \$2K per project, 500 emails = \$4K-\$10K in revenue. If you charge \$3K/month retainer, 500 emails = \$6K-\$15K in monthly recurring revenue.

The list is the foundation. The emails are the lever. Build the list right, and the emails practically write themselves — because you know exactly who you’re talking to and why they need you.

Next chapter: AI-personalized outreach that doesn’t sound like AI wrote it.

## Chapter 3: AI-Personalized Outreach at Scale With Claude

### What You’ll Have After This Chapter

A system that produces personalized emails for each prospect in under 30 seconds — emails that reference specific details about their business, sound like you spent 10 minutes researching them, and cost \$0 in tooling.

### Why Personalization Breaks Cold Email

The average decision-maker receives 120+ emails per day. They can detect a template in under 2 seconds. The delete-or-read decision happens based on two things:

1. **Subject line:** Does it look like it was written for ME?
2. **First sentence:** Does this person know anything about MY business?

If both answers are “no,” your email is dead. If both are “yes,” they read the rest.

Generic personalization (“I love what you’re doing at [COMPANY]”) is as bad as no personalization. It screams template. Real personalization references something specific enough that the recipient thinks “this person actually looked at my stuff.”

### The Personalization Data Pipeline

Before you write any emails, you need personalization data for each prospect. This is the “Personalization Note” column from your spreadsheet in Chapter 2.

### What Makes Good Personalization

**Strong personalization (use these):** - A specific article or blog post they wrote - A recent LinkedIn post and your take on it - A specific feature of their product/website - A recent company milestone (funding, launch, hire, award) - A specific number from their business (if publicly available) - A mutual connection or shared community

**Weak personalization (avoid these):** - “I love your website” (everyone says this) - “Congrats on your recent growth” (vague) - “I noticed you’re in the [INDUSTRY] space” (obviously) - “Great company you’ve built” (hollow)

## Gathering Personalization Data (2 minutes per prospect)

For each prospect, do this:

1. **Visit their website** (30 seconds): Note one specific thing — a product feature, a design choice, a piece of copy, a blog post title. Not “nice website” — something like “I noticed your checkout page has a progress bar with estimated delivery dates.”
2. **Check their LinkedIn** (30 seconds): Read their most recent post. Note the topic and your genuine reaction. If they haven’t posted, check their profile headline or About section for something specific.
3. **Check their Twitter** (30 seconds): Read their last 3-5 tweets. Find one you can reference.
4. **Check for news** (30 seconds): Google “[Company Name] news” or “[Person’s Name] [Company Name].” Recent press coverage, podcast appearances, or events are gold.

Record the best data point in your spreadsheet’s Personalization Note column.

Example entries: - “Published article about CAC payback periods in SaaS on LinkedIn last week” - “Website homepage loads in 7.2 seconds (GTmetrix), competitor loads in 1.8s” - “Just launched a new product line on Shopify, announced it on Twitter March 3” - “Speaking at SaaSOpen in June on pricing strategies”

## Using Claude for Personalization at Scale

Here’s where the system gets powerful. Instead of writing each email from scratch, you use Claude to generate personalized emails from your data.

### The Master Prompt

This prompt produces consistently good cold emails. The key is giving Claude enough constraints that it can’t produce slop.

I'm sending a cold email to a prospect. Write the email using the data below.

My service: [DESCRIBE WHAT YOU DO IN ONE SENTENCE]

My best result: [YOUR TOP CASE STUDY — specific numbers]

Prospect details:

- Name: {{FIRST\_NAME}}
- Company: {{COMPANY}}
- Title: {{TITLE}}
- Personalization data: {{PERSONALIZATION\_NOTE}}

Rules:

1. First sentence must reference the personalization data specifically
  - not generically

2. Second sentence connects their situation to the problem I solve
3. Third sentence states my result with a specific number
4. Fourth sentence is the CTA – a question, not a demand
5. Total email: under 75 words
6. Subject line: under 5 words, references them not me
7. No "I hope this finds you well"
8. No "I'd love to hop on a quick call"
9. No exclamation marks
10. No compliments that could apply to anyone
11. Tone: peer-to-peer, not salesperson-to-prospect
12. Sign off with first name only, no title or company

## Real Example

**Input data:** - Name: Sarah - Company: Bloom Skincare - Title: Founder -  
Personalization: "Just launched DTC Shopify store, mentioned struggling with paid ads on Twitter March 8"

### Output:

Subject: Bloom's ad spend

Sarah,

Saw your tweet about the paid ads struggle after the Shopify launch. Most DTC skincare brands I've worked with were burning 40–60% of ad spend on audiences that would never convert.

I helped a similar brand (Glow Labs, \$2M ARR) cut their CAC by 52% in 6 weeks by restructuring their Meta ad targeting around purchase-intent signals instead of interest-based audiences.

Would it be useful to see the exact targeting framework we used?

Alex

73 words. Specific reference. Specific result. Low-pressure CTA.

## The Batch Process

Here's how to personalize 50 emails in 30 minutes:

1. Open your prospect spreadsheet
2. Take 10 prospects at a time
3. Paste the master prompt into Claude with all 10 prospects' data
4. Ask Claude to generate all 10 emails at once

Modified batch prompt:

Generate 10 cold emails using my master template. Each email must be unique –  
different first sentences, different angles, different CTAs.

My service: [DESCRIPTION]

My best result: [RESULT]

[Paste the master prompt rules from above]

Prospects:

1. Name: Sarah, Company: Bloom Skincare, Title: Founder  
Personalization: Just launched DTC Shopify store, struggling with paid ads (Twitter March 8)
2. Name: Marcus, Company: DevStack, Title: CEO  
Personalization: Published blog post about developer burnout, 200+ comments on HN
3. Name: Priya, Company: NutriPlan, Title: Co-founder  
Personalization: Website loads in 8.1 seconds, competitor MealPrep Pro loads in 1.4s

[Continue for all 10]

Claude generates all 10 emails in about 90 seconds. Review each one — spend 10-15 seconds per email checking that the personalization feels genuine and the CTA is clear. Adjust anything that feels off.

50 prospects = 5 batches = 30 minutes of your time.

## Quality Control Checklist

Before sending any AI-generated email, check:

- ☐ Does the first sentence reference something only THEY would recognize?
- ☐ Would this email make sense if sent to a different prospect? (If yes, it's too generic — rewrite)
- ☐ Is the result specific? (Not “improved results” but “cut CAC by 52%”)
- ☐ Is the CTA a question they can answer with one sentence?
- ☐ Is it under 80 words?
- ☐ Does it sound like a human wrote it? (Read it out loud. If it sounds like AI, rewrite)

## Anti-Slop Vocabulary List

Tell Claude to never use these words in cold emails:

- “Leverage” (use “use”)
- “Synergy” (delete)
- “Innovative” (prove it with a number instead)
- “Cutting-edge” (meaningless)
- “Circle back” (use “follow up”)
- “Reach out” (you already did — you’re emailing them)
- “Touch base” (use “check in”)
- “In today’s landscape” (delete)



- “Unlock” (delete)
- “Elevate” (delete)
- “Transform” (use “change” or better, describe the specific change)
- “Best-in-class” (everyone says this)

Add this to your prompt: “Do not use any corporate jargon, buzzwords, or filler phrases. Write like a smart friend sending a casual but professional email.”

## Personalization Tiers

Not every prospect deserves the same level of personalization. Tier your list:

### **Tier 1: High-Value Prospects (top 10%)**

These are your dream clients. Spend 5-10 minutes per email. Research their business deeply. Reference multiple data points. Maybe record a 60-second Loom video showing something specific about their website you’d fix.

Expected response rate: 15-30%

### **Tier 2: Good-Fit Prospects (middle 40%)**

Solid matches for your service. Spend 2-3 minutes per email. One strong personalization data point. Use the Claude batch process.

Expected response rate: 5-12%

### **Tier 3: Worth-a-Shot Prospects (bottom 50%)**

They fit your ICP broadly but you don’t have strong personalization data. Use a lighter template with just their name, company, and industry. Focus on a compelling result rather than deep personalization.

Expected response rate: 2-5%

The mistake most people make is treating all 500 prospects the same. Spend 80% of your personalization effort on Tier 1 and Tier 2. Tier 3 is volume — send enough and the numbers work even at low response rates.

## The Subject Line System

Subject lines determine whether your email gets opened. Here’s what works in cold email:

**Format 1: Their company name** - “Bloom Skincare” — simple, looks like internal communication - Open rate: typically 45-65%

**Format 2: Mutual reference** - “John mentioned you” — only if it’s true - Open rate: 55-75%

**Format 3: Specific observation** - “Your checkout page” — references something specific - Open rate: 40-55%

**Format 4: Short question** - “Quick question” — overused but still works - Open rate: 35-50%

**What fails:** - “Increase Your Revenue by 300%” — spam filter instant kill - “Exciting Opportunity for Bloom Skincare” — screams sales email - Anything over 6 words - Anything with ALL CAPS or emojis

Test 2-3 subject line formats across your first 100 sends. Track which gets the highest reply rate (not open rate — you’re not tracking opens, remember). Double down on what works.

## Maintaining Authenticity

The point of using AI for personalization is speed, not deception. You’re using it to say what you would say if you had 10 minutes per email instead of 30 seconds. The personalization data is real. The observations are real. The results you cite are real. Claude is just the writing assistant.

If at any point an email feels dishonest — you’re claiming to have noticed something you didn’t, or referencing a conversation that didn’t happen — delete it and write that section manually.

The moment personalization feels fake, it performs worse than no personalization at all.

Next chapter: Seven proven email sequences with exact templates.

# Chapter 4: Seven Proven Email Sequences With Templates

## What You’ll Have After This Chapter

Seven complete email sequences you can deploy today — each with the initial email and 3-4 follow-ups. Pick the sequence that matches your situation, fill in the variables, and start sending.

## How Sequences Work

A sequence is a series of emails sent to the same prospect over time. Here’s why sequences matter:

- Email 1: 2-5% reply rate
- Email 2: Additional 3-4% reply rate
- Email 3: Additional 2-3% reply rate
- Email 4: Additional 1-2% reply rate

Total sequence reply rate: 8-14%. That's 3-5x higher than sending a single email.

The key insight: **Most replies come from follow-ups, not the first email.** The first email gets their attention. The follow-ups get their response.

## Sequence Timing

- Email 1: Day 0 (initial send)
- Email 2: Day 3 (first follow-up)
- Email 3: Day 7 (second follow-up)
- Email 4: Day 14 (breakup email)

All follow-ups should be replies to the original thread (same subject line, same email chain). This pushes the whole conversation up in their inbox.

---

## Sequence 1: The Problem Spotter

**Best for:** Service providers who can identify a specific, fixable problem on the prospect's website or in their marketing.

### Email 1 — The Observation

Subject: {{COMPANY}}'s [specific thing]

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

I was looking at {{COMPANY}}'s [website/ads/email flow] and noticed [SPECIFIC PROBLEM – be precise, not vague].

This usually costs companies like yours [SPECIFIC CONSEQUENCE – e.g., "15-30% of mobile visitors" or "\$2K-5K/month in lost revenue"].

I fixed this exact issue for {{SIMILAR\_COMPANY}} and they saw [SPECIFIC RESULT] within [TIMEFRAME].

Want me to send over what we did? Takes 2 minutes to read.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

### Email 2 — Day 3 Follow-Up

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Quick follow-up on the [SPECIFIC PROBLEM] I mentioned.

Here's a 60-second breakdown of the fix:  
[2-3 BULLET POINTS explaining the solution at a high level]

Happy to walk through how this would apply to {{COMPANY}} specifically.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

### Email 3 — Day 7 Follow-Up

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Wanted to share a quick case study that's relevant to {{COMPANY}}.

{{SIMILAR\_COMPANY}} had the same [PROBLEM] I noticed on your [website/funnel/ads]. After [WHAT WE DID], they went from [BEFORE METRIC] to [AFTER METRIC] in [TIMEFRAME].

If you're interested, I can put together a similar breakdown for {{COMPANY}} – no charge, no commitment.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

### Email 4 — Day 14 Breakup

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

I've reached out a few times about the [SPECIFIC PROBLEM] on {{COMPANY}}'s [website/funnel]. Totally understand if the timing isn't right.

I'll leave this here – if [PROBLEM] becomes a priority down the road, happy to pick this back up.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

---

## Sequence 2: The Social Proof Lead

**Best for:** When you have a strong case study in the prospect's exact industry.

### Email 1

Subject: How {{SIMILAR\_COMPANY}} [achieved result]

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

{{SIMILAR\_COMPANY}} was [SITUATION SIMILAR TO PROSPECT'S] before we started working together.

In [TIMEFRAME], we helped them [SPECIFIC RESULT WITH NUMBER] by [ONE-SENTENCE DESCRIPTION OF WHAT YOU DID].

{{COMPANY}} is in a similar position. Would it be worth 15 minutes to walk through exactly what we did?

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

## **Email 2 — Day 3**

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

One more detail on the {{SIMILAR\_COMPANY}} project I mentioned.

The biggest win wasn't [OBVIOUS METRIC]. It was [UNEXPECTED SECONDARY BENEFIT – e.g., "they cut their agency spend by 40% while getting better results" or "their team went from 12 hours/week on X to 2"].

Is this the kind of outcome that would be useful for {{COMPANY}}?

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

## **Email 3 — Day 7**

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

I put together a 1-page breakdown of the {{SIMILAR\_COMPANY}} project:

- Where they started: [METRIC]
- What we changed: [ACTION]
- Where they are now: [RESULT]
- Timeline: [DURATION]

Happy to send it over if you're curious – or if you know someone else at {{COMPANY}} this would be relevant for, feel free to forward.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

## **Email 4 — Day 14**

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Closing the loop on this – seems like the timing might not be right for {{COMPANY}}, and that's completely fine.

If [SERVICE AREA] becomes a focus later this year, I'm an easy person to ping.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

---

## Sequence 3: The Value-First (Free Audit)

**Best for:** When you can provide tangible value before asking for anything. Works exceptionally well for SEO, web design, email marketing, and conversion optimization.

### Email 1

Subject: {{COMPANY}} audit

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

I did a quick [SEO/conversion/email/ad] audit of {{COMPANY}}'s [website/funnel/campaigns] and found 3 things worth looking at:

1. [SPECIFIC FINDING #1]
2. [SPECIFIC FINDING #2]
3. [SPECIFIC FINDING #3]

I recorded a 3-minute video walking through each one with suggestions. Want me to send it over?

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

### Email 2 — Day 3

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Following up on the audit findings. Here's a quick preview of finding #1:

[2-3 SENTENCES explaining the most impactful finding and the fix]

This alone could [ESTIMATED IMPACT]. The other 2 findings are in the video – just say the word and I'll send the link.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

### Email 3 — Day 7

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

I'll leave the video link here in case it's useful:

[LOOM/VIDEO LINK]

No strings attached – these are fixes your team can implement without my help. If you want a deeper dive after watching, happy to chat.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

## Email 4 — Day 14

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Last note on this. The video covers 3 quick wins for {{COMPANY}}. Even if we never work together, the fixes are worth implementing.

Link is above if you want to check it out. Either way, all the best with {{COMPANY}}.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

**Why this sequence works:** You've already done the work. Most prospects feel a combination of curiosity and reciprocity — they want to see what you found, and they feel a natural obligation to at least respond because you invested effort.

---

## Sequence 4: The Referral Ask

**Best for:** When your contact isn't the right person but might know who is.

### Email 1

Subject: Quick question

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

I help [TYPE OF COMPANY] with [SPECIFIC OUTCOME]. I've been trying to connect with whoever handles [FUNCTION – marketing, web development, growth, etc.] at {{COMPANY}}.

Would you be the right person to talk to about this, or could you point me to who is?

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

### Email 2 — Day 3

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Just a quick bump on this – trying to find the right person at {{COMPANY}} who handles [FUNCTION].

If that's not you, would you mind pointing me in the right direction? Takes 10 seconds.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

### Email 3 — Day 7

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Last try on this. Would [PERSON'S NAME – guess based on LinkedIn research] be the right contact for [FUNCTION] at {{COMPANY}}?

If so, I'll reach out to them directly.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

**Why this works:** Asking “are you the right person?” has a surprisingly high response rate because it’s a low-effort question. People either say “yes” (and now you’re in a conversation) or they forward you to the right person (warm intro).

---

## Sequence 5: The Trigger Event

**Best for:** When something just happened at the company that makes your service immediately relevant — new funding, new hire, product launch, expansion.

### Email 1

Subject: Congrats on [TRIGGER EVENT]

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Saw the news about {{COMPANY}} [SPECIFIC TRIGGER – "raising your Series A," "launching the new product line," "expanding to the UK market"].

When [SIMILAR COMPANY] hit the same milestone, they ran into [SPECIFIC CHALLENGE THAT COMES NEXT]. We helped them [SPECIFIC SOLUTION] and they [SPECIFIC RESULT].

Is [CHALLENGE] on your radar right now?

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

### Email 2 — Day 3

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

One thing I didn't mention – after [TRIGGER EVENT], the biggest time-sensitive issue is usually [SPECIFIC URGENT CHALLENGE].



If you wait [TIMEFRAME], [CONSEQUENCE]. But if you address it now, [POSITIVE OUTCOME].

Worth a 10-minute conversation to see if this applies to {{COMPANY}}'s situation?

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

### **Email 3 — Day 10**

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Quick check-in. I know post-[TRIGGER EVENT] things move fast.

If [CHALLENGE] becomes a priority, I've got a framework that's worked for 3 other companies in your exact situation. Happy to share it – takes 5 minutes to walk through.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

---

## **Sequence 6: The Mutual Connection**

**Best for:** When you share a connection, community, or event with the prospect.

### **Email 1**

Subject: [MUTUAL CONNECTION'S NAME] / {{COMPANY}}

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

[MUTUAL CONNECTION] and I were talking about [TOPIC], and your name came up. [He/She] mentioned you're [SPECIFIC CONTEXT – "scaling {{COMPANY}}'s marketing," "rebuilding your website," "looking for ways to reduce churn"].

I've helped [SIMILAR COMPANIES] with exactly that – specifically, [ONE-SENTENCE RESULT].

Worth connecting? I'll keep it short – 15 minutes max.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

P.S. If [MUTUAL CONNECTION] didn't mention me, I promise this isn't as random as it looks. [BRIEF CONTEXT].

## Email 2 — Day 4

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Following up on the note from last week. [MUTUAL CONNECTION] thought we'd be a good fit to connect around [TOPIC].

I put together a quick overview of what we did for [SIMILAR COMPANY] – happy to share it if useful.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

## Email 3 — Day 10

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Last note on this. If the timing isn't right, no worries at all.

If [CHALLENGE] becomes a priority later, I'm easy to find – feel free to circle back anytime.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

---

## Sequence 7: The Content-First Approach

**Best for:** Prospects who are active content consumers (they read blogs, engage on LinkedIn, subscribe to newsletters).

### Email 1

Subject: Thought you'd find this useful

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

I saw your [LinkedIn post/tweet/comment] about [TOPIC]. It reminded me of a piece I wrote on [RELATED TOPIC]:

[LINK TO YOUR ARTICLE/VIDEO/RESOURCE]

The key insight: [ONE-SENTENCE SUMMARY OF THE CONTENT].

Curious if you've tried [SPECIFIC APPROACH FROM THE CONTENT] at {{COMPANY}}.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

## Email 2 — Day 4

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Another resource related to what you posted about [TOPIC]:

[DIFFERENT PIECE OF CONTENT – someone else's, not yours]

The data in here about [SPECIFIC DATA POINT] is worth looking at, especially for companies at {{COMPANY}}'s stage.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

## Email 3 — Day 8

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

One more thing on [TOPIC]. I've been working with [SIMILAR COMPANIES] on this exact challenge, and the pattern I keep seeing is [INSIGHT].

If you're currently tackling [CHALLENGE] at {{COMPANY}}, I'd be happy to share what's working for others in your space.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

## Email 4 — Day 14

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

I'll stop filling your inbox. If [TOPIC] stays on your plate and you want to compare notes with someone who works on this daily, I'm around.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

**Why this works:** You're not selling. You're sharing value, building familiarity, and positioning yourself as an expert. By email 3, when you mention working with similar companies, it's a natural transition — not a cold pitch.

---

## Which Sequence to Use

| Situation                                               | Use Sequence         |
|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| You found a specific problem on their website/marketing | 1: Problem Spotter   |
| You have a strong case study in their industry          | 2: Social Proof Lead |

| Situation                                              | Use Sequence         |
|--------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| You can provide a free audit or video review           | 3: Value-First       |
| You're not sure who the decision-maker is              | 4: Referral Ask      |
| They just raised funding, launched, or hit a milestone | 5: Trigger Event     |
| You share a connection, community, or event            | 6: Mutual Connection |
| They're active on social media and engage with content | 7: Content-First     |

## Sequence Rules

1. **Never send more than 4 emails in a sequence.** After 4, you're annoying, not persistent.
2. **Always reply to the same thread.** New subject lines for follow-ups get lower response rates.
3. **Each follow-up must add new information.** Don't just say "following up." Add a case study, an insight, a question — something new.
4. **Remove anyone who replies negatively.** "Not interested" means stop. Immediately.
5. **Track replies, not opens.** Open tracking kills deliverability. Reply rate is the only metric that matters.

Next chapter: What to do when they reply — handling responses, booking calls, and closing the deal.

# Chapter 5: Reply Handling, Call Booking, and Closing

## What You'll Have After This Chapter

A complete system for handling every type of reply, booking discovery calls, running those calls, and sending proposals that close. This is where cold emails become revenue.

## Reply Classification

Every reply falls into one of six categories. Each requires a different response:

## Category 1: Positive Interest

“Sure, send me more info.” “Sounds interesting. Let’s chat.” “What does this look like for a company our size?”

### Response (within 2 hours):

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Great to hear from you. Here's a quick overview:

[2-3 BULLET POINTS answering their specific question]

The best way to see if this is a fit is a quick call – usually takes 15-20 minutes.

Here are a few times that work this week:

- [DAY, TIME RANGE]
- [DAY, TIME RANGE]
- [DAY, TIME RANGE]

Or grab a time that works for you: [CALENDLY/CAL.COM LINK]

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

**Key rules:** - Respond within 2 hours. Response time is your biggest conversion lever. - Always suggest 3 specific times AND a scheduling link. - Don’t send a PDF deck or long proposal. They asked for “more info” — give them enough to say yes to a call, not enough to make a decision without talking to you.

## Category 2: Soft Interest

“Can you tell me more about pricing?” “What results do you typically get?” “How is this different from [competitor/alternative]?”

### Response:

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Good question. Here's the quick version:

[DIRECT ANSWER TO THEIR QUESTION – 2-3 sentences, not a novel]

For a more detailed breakdown specific to {{COMPANY}}, it's usually easier to walk through it live. I can share some examples from [SIMILAR INDUSTRY/COMPANY] on a quick call.

Would [DAY] or [DAY] work for 15 minutes?

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

**Key rule:** Answer their question directly. Don't dodge pricing or hide behind "it depends." If they ask about pricing, give them a range: "For a company like {{COMPANY}}, typical projects run \$3K-\$8K depending on scope." Then move to the call.

### Category 3: Not the Right Person

"I'm not the person for this. Try reaching out to [NAME]." "That's handled by our [DEPARTMENT]."

**Response:**

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Appreciate you pointing me in the right direction. Would you mind making a quick intro to [SUGGESTED PERSON]? Even a one-line email would be huge.

If it's easier, I can draft the intro email and you just forward it.

Thanks again.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

Then follow up with the suggested person:

Subject: [REFERRING PERSON] suggested I reach out

Hi [NEW CONTACT],

[REFERRING PERSON] on your team pointed me your way – [he/she] thought you'd be the right person to chat with about [SPECIFIC TOPIC].

[ONE SENTENCE about what you do and a result].

Worth a quick conversation?

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

**Key rule:** The warm referral email has a 3-5x higher response rate than the original cold email. Don't waste this intro — be concise and specific.

### Category 4: "Not Right Now"

"Thanks for reaching out, but we're not looking at this right now." "Maybe in Q3." "Not a priority currently."

**Response:**

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

Totally understand. I'll reach back out in [THEIR TIMEFRAME – or Q3 if they said Q3, or 3 months if they were vague].

In the meantime, if anything changes or [TRIGGER EVENT – "you start planning next quarter's budget," "the team decides to revisit this"], feel free to reach out.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

**Key rule:** Set a calendar reminder for the date they mentioned. When you follow up 3 months later, reference this conversation: “We talked in March and you mentioned Q3 might be a better time. Is that still the case?”

“Not now” replies close at 8-15% when you follow up at the right time.

## Category 5: Objections

“We already have someone for this.” “Too expensive.” “We tried this before and it didn’t work.”

### Responses by objection:

#### “We have someone for this”

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

No problem. Out of curiosity – how's that going? Most companies I talk to that already have [SERVICE TYPE] tell me one of two things: they're thrilled with the results, or they feel like they're overpaying for what they're getting.

If you ever want a second opinion on the work, I'm happy to do a quick review – no pitch, just honest feedback.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

#### “Too expensive”

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

I hear you. Can I ask – too expensive compared to what you're spending now, or compared to what you expected?

Just trying to understand your budget range. Sometimes there's a smaller-scope version that makes more sense as a starting point.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

#### “Tried this before, didn’t work”

{{FIRST\_NAME}},

That's fair. Do you mind sharing what went wrong? I ask because when [SERVICE TYPE] fails, it's usually one of 3 things:

1. [COMMON FAILURE REASON 1]
2. [COMMON FAILURE REASON 2]
3. [COMMON FAILURE REASON 3]

If your experience was different, I'm curious what happened. Not trying to sell you – genuinely want to understand so I can avoid those pitfalls with my own clients.

{{YOUR\_FIRST\_NAME}}

## Category 6: Hard No / Unsubscribe

“Not interested, please don’t contact me again.” “Remove me from your list.”

**Response:** Remove them immediately. Don’t reply. Don’t try to convince them. Mark them as “Do Not Contact” in your spreadsheet. Continuing to email someone who asked you to stop is both unethical and, depending on jurisdiction, illegal (CAN-SPAM, GDPR).

## Booking the Discovery Call

### Setting Up Free Scheduling

**Cal.com** (free tier): Open-source Calendly alternative. Unlimited booking pages, calendar integration, automatic timezone detection.

1. Create an account at [cal.com](https://cal.com)
2. Connect your Google Calendar
3. Create a “Discovery Call” event type:
  - Duration: 20 minutes (not 30 — tighter meetings = less resistance to booking)
  - Buffer: 10 minutes before and after
  - Available hours: 9 AM - 4 PM your timezone, Monday-Thursday
  - Minimum notice: 4 hours (prevents same-day bookings you’re not prepared for)
4. Add a pre-call question: “What’s the one thing you’d want to solve on this call?”

Include the Cal.com link in every positive reply. The fewer steps between “yes” and booked call, the better.

### Pre-Call Preparation (10 minutes per call)

Before every discovery call:

1. **Re-read the email thread.** Know exactly what they responded to and what interested them.
2. **Visit their website.** Note 2-3 specific things you’d improve. Not generic — specific.



3. **Check their LinkedIn.** Read their recent posts. Know their background.
4. **Prepare your case study.** The one most similar to their situation. Have numbers ready.
5. **Write down your opening question.** Not “tell me about your business.” Something specific: “I saw you launched [X] last month — how’s that going?”

## Running the Discovery Call

The discovery call has one goal: determine if there’s a fit and agree on next steps. You’re not pitching on this call. You’re diagnosing.

### Call Structure (20 minutes)

#### Minutes 1-2: Open

“Thanks for hopping on, {{FIRST\_NAME}}. Before I dive in — you mentioned [REFERENCE THEIR PRE-CALL ANSWER OR EMAIL]. Can you expand on that?”

Let them talk. This isn’t your monologue.

#### Minutes 3-10: Diagnosis

Ask these questions in order. Each one builds on the previous:

1. “What’s the biggest challenge you’re facing with [AREA]?”
2. “How are you handling it right now?”
3. “What’s the impact of not solving this?” (Get them to quantify — “We’re losing X customers a month” or “It takes us Y hours per week”)
4. “What have you tried before? What worked and what didn’t?”
5. “If we could fix this, what would success look like for you?”

#### Minutes 10-15: Position

“Based on what you’ve told me, here’s what I’d recommend...”

Share your approach — not a full proposal, but the high-level strategy. Reference your case study: “We did something similar for [COMPANY] and they went from [BEFORE] to [AFTER] in [TIMEFRAME].”

#### Minutes 15-18: Scope and Budget

“For a project like this, typical investment is [RANGE]. Does that align with what you had in mind?”

If they flinch at the price, ask: “What budget were you thinking?” Don’t negotiate on the call. Adjust scope, not price.

#### Minutes 18-20: Next Steps

“Here’s what I suggest as next steps: I’ll send over a proposal by [DATE — within 48 hours]. It’ll outline exactly what we’d do, the timeline, and the investment. Sound good?”

Get a verbal commitment to review the proposal by a specific date: “Can you take a look by Friday and let me know where you land?”

## The Proposal Template

Send the proposal within 48 hours of the call. Delays kill deals. Use this structure:

PROPOSAL: [PROJECT NAME] for {{COMPANY}}

Prepared for: {{FIRST\_NAME}} {{LAST\_NAME}}, {{TITLE}}

Prepared by: {{YOUR\_NAME}}, {{YOUR\_COMPANY}}

Date: {{DATE}}

---

### THE CHALLENGE

[2–3 sentences summarizing what they told you on the call. Use their exact words. When they see their own language reflected back, they feel understood.]

### THE APPROACH

Phase 1: [WHAT YOU'LL DO FIRST] (Week 1–2)

- [Deliverable]
- [Deliverable]
- [Deliverable]

Phase 2: [WHAT YOU'LL DO NEXT] (Week 3–4)

- [Deliverable]
- [Deliverable]

Phase 3: [FINAL PHASE] (Week 5–6)

- [Deliverable]
- [Deliverable]

### EXPECTED OUTCOMES

Based on similar projects (e.g., {{SIMILAR\_COMPANY}}):

- [SPECIFIC METRIC]: [EXPECTED IMPROVEMENT]
- [SPECIFIC METRIC]: [EXPECTED IMPROVEMENT]
- [SPECIFIC METRIC]: [EXPECTED IMPROVEMENT]

### INVESTMENT

Option A: [FULL SCOPE] – \$[PRICE]

Option B: [REDUCED SCOPE] – \$[LOWER PRICE]

[Include payment terms: 50% upfront, 50% on completion.

Or: monthly retainer billed on the 1st.]

## TIMELINE

Start date: [DATE – within 1–2 weeks of signing]

Estimated completion: [DATE]

## NEXT STEPS

1. Review this proposal
2. Let me know which option works (or if you have questions)
3. I'll send the contract via [TOOL – HelloSign, DocuSign, PandaDoc free tier]
4. We kick off on [DATE]

This proposal is valid for 14 days.

---

{{YOUR\_NAME}}

{{YOUR\_EMAIL}}

{{YOUR\_PHONE}}

## Why Two Options

Always present two options (not three — three creates decision paralysis). The two-option structure:

- **Option A** is your recommended scope (and the one you want them to buy)
- **Option B** is a smaller scope at a lower price

Most people choose Option A because they don't want to feel like they're getting the "cheap" version. But Option B prevents losing the deal entirely over price.

Never present Option B as "basic" or "starter." Frame it as: "This focuses on [CORE DELIVERABLE] first, and we can expand to Phase 2 once we see results."

## After the Proposal

### Follow-Up Timing

- **Day 2** (if no response): "Hey {{FIRST\_NAME}}, just checking that the proposal came through. Any questions I can answer?"
- **Day 5**: "Wanted to see where you landed on the proposal. Happy to hop on a quick call to walk through anything."
- **Day 10**: "Following up one more time. If the timing isn't right, I totally understand — just let me know either way so I can plan my schedule."
- **Day 14**: "The proposal I sent over expires today. If you'd like to move forward, let me know and I'll extend it. If not, no worries — happy to revisit in the future."

## Closing Techniques That Aren't Sleazy

**The Assumptive Close:** After they say they like the proposal, say: “Great. I’ll send the contract over today. Does a [DATE] start date work for you?”

**The Timeline Close:** “I have availability starting [DATE]. After that, my next opening is [LATER DATE]. If you’d like to start sooner, let me know by [DATE].”

**The Value Reframe:** If they hesitate on price: “Just to put this in context — this project pays for itself once [SPECIFIC OUTCOME] happens. Based on {{SIMILAR\_COMPANY}}’s results, that usually happens within [TIMEFRAME].”

## The Closed-Won System

After they sign:

1. **Send a welcome email** within 1 hour. Outline what happens next, who they’ll work with, and when the first deliverable is due.
2. **Collect payment** immediately. Invoice same day via Stripe, Wave (free), or PayPal invoice.
3. **Set up the project** in your project management tool (Notion free tier, Trello free, Linear free).
4. **Deliver early** on the first milestone. Under-promise, over-deliver on the first deliverable. This sets the tone for the entire engagement.

## Pipeline Tracking

Track your entire pipeline in a Google Sheet:

| Prospect  | Status        | First Email Date | Last Contact | Response Type | Call Date | Proposal Sent | Deal Value | Notes                  |
|-----------|---------------|------------------|--------------|---------------|-----------|---------------|------------|------------------------|
| Sarah Kim | Proposal sent | Mar 1            | Mar 10       | Positive      | Mar 8     | Mar 10        | \$5,000    | Opti A, waiti on decis |

Update this daily. It takes 2 minutes. When you can see your entire pipeline, you can forecast revenue, identify bottlenecks (too few emails? too few calls? proposals not closing?), and adjust.

## The Numbers (Full Funnel)

Here’s a realistic cold email-to-revenue funnel:

500 prospects emailed  
→ 40 replies (8% reply rate)

- 25 positive/interested (5% positive rate)
- 12 discovery calls booked (2.4% of total)
- 6 proposals sent (1.2% of total)
- 3 closed deals (0.6% of total)

If your average project is \$3,000: - 500 emails = \$9,000 in revenue - 1,000 emails = \$18,000 in revenue - 2,000 emails = \$36,000 in revenue

Cost: \$30/year in domains. \$0 in tools. Your time to write and send: ~10 hours per 500 emails with the systems from Chapters 1-4.

That's \$900/hour in effective hourly rate at \$9K per 10 hours of work.

The system works. The variable is whether you sit down and send the emails. Everything else is just execution of what's in these five chapters.